the tone of debate within Rakhine. The continuous use of ethnic tensions as a political tool came to a head in 2012.

The 2012 massacres

The events of 2012 can only be described as an attempt at ethnic cleansing seeking to drive the Rohingyas either out of the country, or, at the least, from their homes and into internal refugee camps.[12] The initial violence started in June 2012 in four townships and spread to nine more in October, as initial acts of random violence was turned into a systematic attempt to force the Rohingyas to leave the state.[13]

The events in June commenced after the rape and murder of a Rakhine woman by three Muslims[14] in late May. On 3 June, a large group of Rakhine Buddhists stopped a bus and killed the ten Muslims who were travelling on board. Following this, the violence escalated to attacks on a number of villages and both communities were victims and aggressors in this phase, with armed mobs carrying out acts of murder and arson.

At the start, local security forces, especially the police (who are dominated by Rakhine Buddhists) stood to one side, but later some officials joined in the attacks to burn Muslim villages.[15] In contrast, at least in a few instances, the army tried to stop the violence or protect fleeing Muslims. But more often, they either stood aside, or actively joined in with the attacks.[16] After the June events had died down, the army dumped the bodies of some Rohingyas close to a refugee camp:

> None of the bodies were identified. Local residents took photographs showing some victims who had been ‘hogtied’ with string or plastic strips before being executed. By leaving the bodies near a camp for displaced Rohingya, the soldiers were sending a message—consistent with a policy of ethnic cleansing—that the Rohingya should leave permanently.[17]

Despite the evidence of military and police involvement in the riots, both the EU and the US praised the regime for its even-handed approach to containing the violence.[18] The EU Foreign Affairs Commissioner, Catherine Ashton, felt moved to claim, ‘We believe that the security forces are handling this difficult intercommunal violence in an appropriate way. We welcome the priority which the Myanmar government is giving to dealing with all ethnic conflicts’.[19]